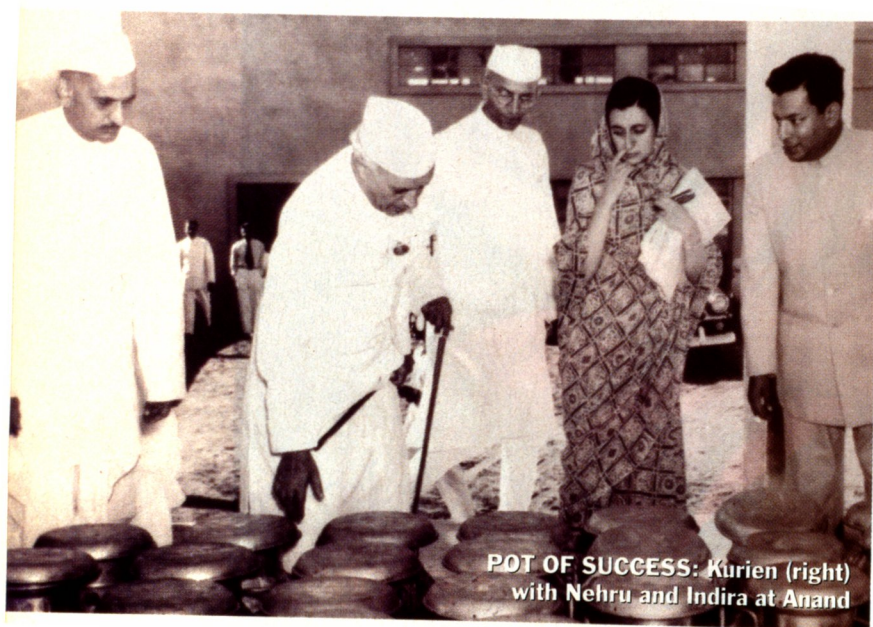


Taste of INDIA

Utterly butterly acquired a new meaning and a cute little girl in polka-dots was identified with a cooperative movement that gave birth to a rural transformation



POT OF SUCCESS: Kurien (right) with Nehru and Indira at Anand

■ By Vergheze Kurien

Certain events are destined: no matter how and why. And since they are aimed at people's good, the obstacles get out of their way in natural course. The story of the formation of the National Dairy Development Board (NDDB) and its Operation Flood that brought about a milk revolution in India is no different.

It was the mid-'60s when I received a call from a senior Gujarat cadre ips officer informing me that Union home secretary L.P. Singh was in Gujarat and wanted to take a look at the cooperative milk model at Anand. Singh was very impressed when he visited Anand and saw the impact of the movement. He asked me why this model, which had created a win-win situation for both the farmers and consumers, couldn't be replicated at the national level. I told him that my proposal titled 'Operation Flood' was facing bureaucratic hurdles and the officials of the Union agriculture ministry were not interested in it. Singh was surprised and he promised to put everything in order. On reaching Delhi, he arranged

an informal meeting with the Union secretaries and asked me to give a presentation on my proposed scheme. At the meeting, I explained to them how the scheme aimed at recovering its initial cost by asking European countries to donate excess powdered milk and butter oil, which they otherwise disposed of as waste, to us. I also informed them that seeking aid for the project was a short-term arrangement aimed at a self-sufficient and farmer-friendly milk model for India and not making it dependent on donor countries. In other words, once the model was fully operational, financial aid to the project was to end. After the meeting, Singh who was already keen on implementing the model at the national level, urged other bureaucrats to lend

their support. And thanks to his efforts, the project not only took off but started moving at a fast pace.

Once the project got the clearance, my next task was to get Food and Agriculture Organisation's (FAO) approval for the proposed cooperative milk model. Accompanied by the then Union agriculture secretary B.R. Patel, I went to Rome to negotiate with FAO for excess powder milk and butter oil from the European countries

100 mt
was India's milk production in 2006-07, up from 55.7 mt in 1991-92

